



A FREE GUIDE FOR HIGH-ACHIEVING WOMEN

Quiet the *Inner Critic*

Five first steps for when you look calm on the outside but feel anxious, stretched thin, and never quite “enough” inside.

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You're doing everything right. So why does it feel like this?

If you're the one who holds it together — at work, at home, for everyone — anxiety often doesn't look like anxiety. It looks like over-preparing, over-giving, and a quiet voice that says whatever you did wasn't enough. High-functioning anxiety hides in plain sight precisely because you keep functioning. Here are five gentle first steps to loosen its grip. None of them require you to do more — most ask you to do a little less.

STEP 1

Name the critic as a voice, not the truth

The inner critic feels like a verdict. It isn't — it's a part of you that learned, long ago, that staying ahead kept you safe. When you notice the harsh thought, try: "That's my critic talking," instead of "That's true." Naming it creates a half-inch of space, and change begins in that space.

STEP 2

Trade "Why am I like this?" for "What do I need right now?"

Self-analysis can quietly become self-attack. The more useful question in a hard moment is forward-looking and kind: what do I actually need — rest, a boundary, a glass of water, five minutes? Meeting a real need beats winning an argument with yourself.

STEP 3

Try the 2-minute grounding practice

Before a big moment — a meeting, a hard conversation — put both feet flat on the floor. Breathe in for four counts, out for six, for one minute. Then name three things you can see and two you can hear. This tells your nervous system you're safe, so your thinking brain can come back online.

STEP 4

Let one thing be 80%

Perfectionism promises safety and delivers exhaustion. Pick one low-stakes task this week and deliberately do it at 80%. Notice that the world holds. You're gathering evidence that your worth isn't the same as your output.

STEP 5

Borrow a nervous system

We're not meant to regulate alone — we settle in connection with people who feel safe. That's a text to a friend, a walk with someone who gets it, or the steady presence of a good therapist or group. Reaching out isn't weakness; it's how humans are built to heal.

When is it time to reach out for support? If the anxiety is constant, if it's affecting your sleep, relationships, or ability to enjoy things, or if you're just tired of white-knuckling it alone — that's reason enough. You don't have to be in crisis to deserve help.

You don't have to figure this out alone.

I'm Emily M. Jones — a Licensed Clinical Social Worker and Certified Group Psychotherapist in Arlington and McLean, Virginia (and by video across VA, DC & Utah). I help high-achieving adults and couples work through anxiety, trauma, and the patterns that keep them stuck — with a warm, direct, down-to-earth approach. I also run a therapy group specifically for professional women who are ready to feel more grounded and connected.

Curious whether we'd be a good fit?

The first step is a free, no-pressure 15-minute consultation.

Book a free consultation

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